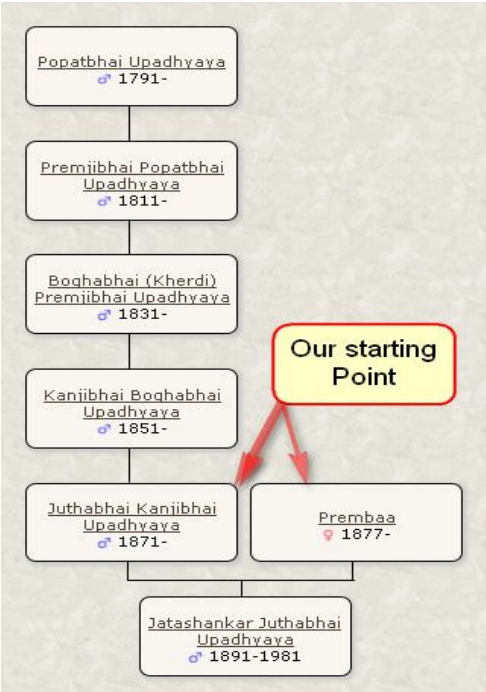
Roots - Jatashankar Juthabhai Upadhyaya (First Draft)

By Mahesh Upadhyaya



My starting point is my great grandfather, Juthabhai Kanjibhai Upadhyaya (Juthadada).

We have 3 places of interest

- Dholra
- Patanvav
- Kherdi

Family has connections with all three places. So I am going to go for Dholra as the family home of Juthadada's parents, Kanjibhai and Ma.
It is very likely that Kanjibhai had a farm in Dholra. he had 3 sons, Juthabhai, Valjibhai and Prabhashankerbhai, and one daughter, Kasaliba.

Juthadada was probably born Dholra , in early 1870's.
He would have moved to Patanvav to improve job prospects and get a teaching Job.
It is very likely, that another farm was bought in Kherdi, around this time.
Juthadada would have started as a teacher around 1888-89, in Patanvav and married Premba (*see picture*). It is very likely that the marriage took place in Dholra.
Grand parents of Keshubhai (and Kusumben – of Aden) Shah were also residing in Patanvav. and Juthadada taught children of that family.
Valjibhai continued to farm in Dholra, near Rajkot. Their mother, Ma, lived with Valjibhai in Dholra. I am told that when Ma passed away, she was placed in a bullock cart, and after removing the bullock, was cremated with the cart, in centre of the village.

Dadaji (Prabhashanker) left school after 4 years of studies and went to Rangoon (now Yangon, former capital city of Burma), with Pranshankar Devshankar Upadhyaya
Having tried their luck there, the duo returned. By this time, Keshubhai Shah's grandparents had moved to Aden and so it was, that Dadaji emigrated to Aden in 1901, at the suggestion of Keshubhai Shah's grandfather. Journey was arduous. It took 17 days' sailing in a dhow. He started with a firm called Khimji & sons before moving to British Treasury. He worked for a short time there but soon moved to a Gujarati-Parsi firm, Cowasjee Dinshaw, as bookkeeper. The firm later

changed its name to Hormusjee Cowasjee Dinshaw, after the death of Cowasjee Dinshaw, in 1900.

Pranshankar decided to go north and settled in Amritsar, Punjab. (His grandchildren and great grandchildren still reside in Amritsar and Jalandhar).

Jatubapuji was born on 19 August 1891, in Patanvav. I am guessing that Juthadada relocated to *Kherdi* as a teacher, sometime, after birth of Jatubapuji.

Jatubapuji had 3 sisters, ManiBa (Mota Faiba), Muktafaiba, ManuBa (Nana Faiba) and 1 brother, Krishnashanjker (Krishnakaka)

Kherdi is small village, about 5 miles east of Rajkot (population 3000 approx 2011 census).

Either there was a family farm there or Juthdada acquired a farm there. We do not know whether he actually farmed there or had it leased to a resident farmer. Once he passed his SSC, he started as a teacher in *Kherdi* .

(note: I was in Kherdi , 1958 or 1959, for few days, to attend a marriage – Jyotika Help: It was a cousin from Bhai's maternal side. One morning I enjoyed warm hospitality at our ancestral farm. Water was drawn from the well - kosh or cos - using a pair of bullocks, to irrigate the field. I got the bulls to draw some water and ended the morning by jumping in that deep well. - - Well, I did not know how deep it was as I did not ask)

At some stage, Juthadada gave away the lease of his farm to the sitting farmer and moved to Gondal, probably, to take up a job as a teacher.

Gondal was a princely state, ruled by Bhagvatsinhji. Educated at the Rajkumar College, Rajkot, he went on to University of Edinburgh to qualify as medical doctor, in 1895. Only princely ruler ever to do so. He was a forward thinking moderniser who wrote and published many science books. By 1918, Gondal was the only state in the Western India States Agency to have compulsory education for girls in all villages. In October 1934, on the 50th anniversary of his accession to the throne he gave his weight in gold to charity. He also produced, now ubiquitous, Gujararti Dictionary, spanning 9 or 10 volumes. (we have 7 volumes at home, in Croydon).

Reason I note this here is that these modernising plans would have impact on our family, in later years.

The house was in Bhojrajpura, street no 4. It was a single story house with mud floors, no electrics or latrine.

Jatubapuji and Dadaji's son, Pranshankerkaka, would normally sit on the footpath, studying under the streetlight.

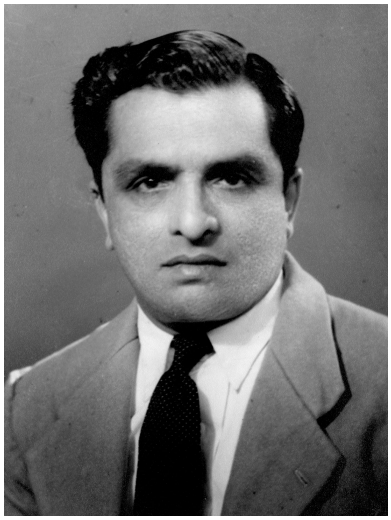
Having completed his secondary school, around 1909, Jatubapuji would have been able to start work, in Gondal, as assistant teacher.

At the age of eighteen, he married Rambhaben Vireshvar Vyas. It is very likely that the marriage took place in Dholra, Gujarat, as I think Rambhaba's family were living in Dholra, at the time.

We know that Rambhaba's brother, Trikamji Vyas, later, relocated to Rajkot and lived in Vijay Plot.

We do not know where Jatubapuji worked in his early years. His first appointment, out of Gujarat state was From January to August

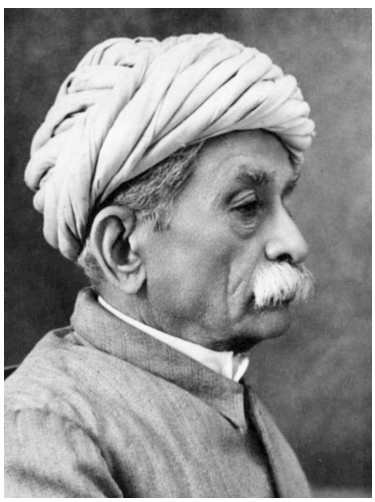
1912 when he worked as an Assistant Teacher in G.T. High School, Bombay.



Jatubapuji took his next post in August 1912, working in Middle School, Dhoraji as 2nd assistant teacher.
Bhai (Mansukhlal Upadhyaya) was born on 27th September 1914, in Dholra, Gujarat. Picture of Rambhaba (shown) was taken when she was carrying Bhai.
Other siblings, Pratap, Mangla and another son died in their infancy. Mangla, especially, was very dear to Bhai. Pratap, probably, passed away in 1916 and on the same day as Juthadada.
Jatubapuji returned to Gondal, in August 1915 to take up his post as a teacher at Sagramji High School with a promotion and an increase in pay of Rs 10 p.m.
Jatubapuji obtained his B.A. Honours in 1919. It is likely that he continued his further studies in Gondal.
We know this, because, in a job application dated 18 May 1930, Jatubabupiji writes “I am a graduate of Bombay University of eleven years’ standing….. .. my special subjects at the B.A. examinations were History and Economics”.

Move to Aden

In Aden, there was a vacancy for headmaster in Anglo Vernacular School for Gujarati boys. The school was started in 1909 by the firm of Hormusjee Cowajee Dinshaw, where Dadaji was a bookkeeper.
Dadaji suggested his nephew Jatubapuji as he had just graduated. Getting a nod from the school governors, Dadaji asked Jatubapuji to apply.
There was a period of confusion as Jatubapuji’s application arrived after the closing date and Jatubapuji having already resigned his present post.
Things eventually got sorted and emergency passport obtained by special permission of a first class magistrate in Gondal. Jatubapuji sailed for Aden in May 1921 and started his post as headmaster of Hormusjee Cowasjee Anglo Gujarati School, Aden, on 1 June 1921.
Rambhaba passed away sometime in 1923 or 1924.

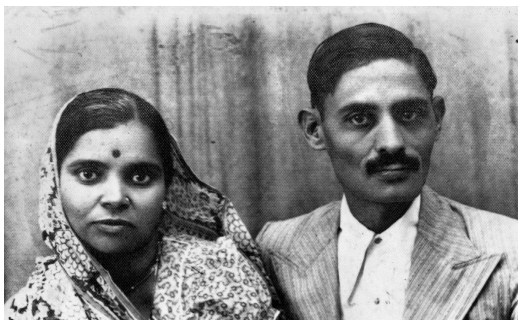


In March 1925, Jatubapuji requested special leave of 4 months to go to India. My guess is, to get married.
Shantaba (born 20 Nov 1909) was the daughter of Pranshanker Bhawanishanker Joshi who was fondly called Joshisaheb.
In 1884, after completing 3rd grade in Gondal, he travelled to Rajkot, using bullock cart as transport, and started in 4th grade. Gandhiji was in 3rd grade at the time. Finishing their secondary school, both enrolled in Samaldas College Bhavnagar. They became good

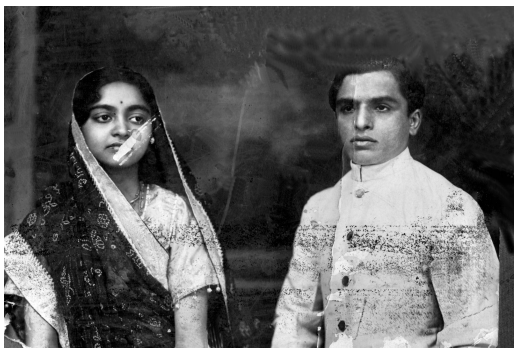
friends. Joshisaheb taught Algebra to Gandhiji as he had problems with the subject.
In 1896, prince of Gondal, Bhagvatsinhji, started Garasia College, based on Rajkumar College, Rajkot. Joshisaheb was appointed assistant teacher there, in 1897. Later, he became principal. In 1922, he was appointed Diwan (first minister) of Gondal.

As the only other graduate in Gondal community and only graduate in Upadhyaya community,

Jatubapuji was a good catch. Shantaba married Jatubapuji in 1925. Shantaba was 16.
Around this time, Krishnakaka joined medical college and later, qualified as medical doctor (MBBS), Jatubapuji supporting him throughout his studies.
Hansaben was born on 5 Jun 1926,
Jitukaka was born 26 Dec 1927
Ushaben was born 4 Jun 1932.
Padmaben was born 19 Jul 1934
Twins Saroj & Sudha,
daughter,Damyanti and another son died in infancy.
I cannot be sure but Bhai would have finished his secondary school in Aden, coming to India 1931/2 for further studies.His ambition was to qualify as a medical doctor. He enrolled at a college in Ahmedabad. Shantaba's younger brother, Krishnakumar Pranshanker Joshi and others were already studying there. Unfortunately, Bhai failed his first year and returned to Aden. Soon after his return, Bhai joined the British Audit office as an audit clerk.
In 1933, Jatubapuji was awarded Secondary Teacher Certificate, giving tail:
BA (Hons) S.T.C.
In 1936, Babukaka emigrated to Aden.
A brahmin was destined to be a priest, a teacher or a cook. A brahmin could teach scriptures or if educated in an English school, teach academia. A brahmin cook was the norm because food could be consumed by anybody if it was prepared by a brahmin.



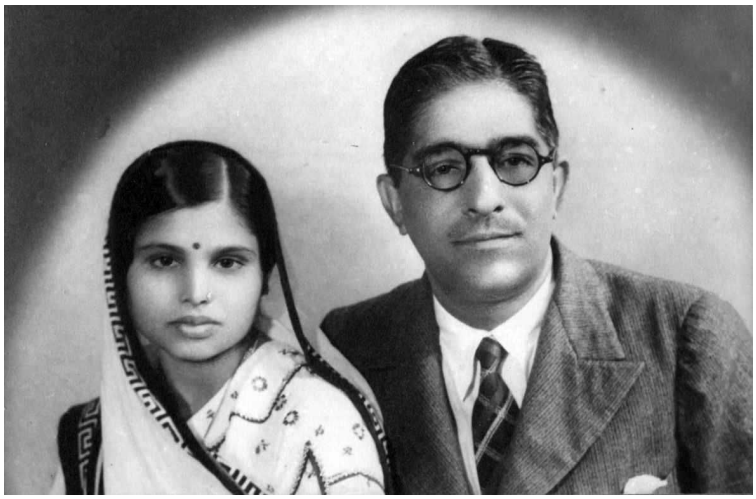
Dulerainana (Dulerai Tribhovan Pandya) and his elder brother, Jagnathbapu, ran a small tea house, in Darbar chowk, Gondal.
One day, he just left everything and ran away to Kashi – Varanasi, without informing his wife,Bhagirathi Ba or anybody else. He spent one month meditating and doing prayers in a Shanker Temple and then decided to go to Katak, Orrissa. (Anglicized version is Cuttack). Just to get it in perspective, Katak is 550 mile from Varanasi and 1200 miles from Gondal.
Once Dulerainana got settled there and got himself a job teaching the local farmers, BhagirathiBa and family joined them there.



Saraswatiba started her primary school in Katak but later, Bhagirathiba returned to Gondal with the children.
In the end of 1936, Jatubapuji took 3 months leave and came to India for the marriage Bhai. Bhai also came.
Babukaka covered his post whilst Bhai was away.
Big renovation work started on the house in Gondal.
Around this time, first floor was built, electricity laid and toilet and bathroom added.

Dulerainana came from Katak to attend the marriage, enduring 5-day train journey.
Marriage took place in Bhagvatpura, Gondal.
It was a great affair, lasting 3 days.
Bhai married Saraswati Dulerai Pandya on 29th January 1937. Saraswatiba was a beautiful girl with big smiling eyes and was just under 14.
After the marriage, Bhai returned to Aden.
Jatubapuji was on 3 months leave, probably to supervise the renovations.
Around this time, Shantaba had complications after miscarriage. Her health deteriorated. Jatubapuji extended his leave. Unfortunately, Shantaba did not survive her illness and passed away on 22 June 1937.

Jatubapuji could not extend his leave as there were staff shortages in Aden. So on 14th July 1937, Sarswatiba and Jatubapuji, returned to Aden with Hansaben, aged 11, Jitukaka, aged 10, Ushaben, aged 5 and Padmaben, aged 3.
Looking after these 4 children was a great responsibility for Sarswatiba , a young girl, aged 14. It must have been a mammoth task to raise these kids, and cope with Bhai's temper, in this strange land.



In 1938, Jatubapuji requested special leave and returned to Gondal in April, on a month's leave. It must have been for marriage to Kanchanba. I understand that there was some opposition because there was an age difference of some 30 years. Jatubapuji and Kanchanba got married in April or May 1938. Kanchanba was 17.

(An edited version, suitable for public access, by Mahesh Upadhyaya)